

How I Became a Ghost Ch. 19-20

By Tim Tingle





Chapter 19

Naomi Meets the Ghost

MY FATHER IS a hunter. So is my brother, Luke. They know the tracks of every animal and beast in the woods and swamps. As they left the woods with my body, I saw Luke tap my father on the shoulder and point to the ground. My father nodded.

They both saw the panther tracks, mixed with those of the wolf. Joseph's secret was no longer a secret to my family. They knew Joseph was the panther.

While my family began their slow walk, Joseph and I returned to the Choctaw Council wagon. At nightfall, while the others finished their meal, Nani Humma ambled to the river. He was looking for us.

"I'm over here," Joseph said, from his hiding spot in the bushes.

“Where is our friend?” Nani Humma asked.

“Isaac is dead,” Joseph said. “A wolf attacked him. His family is carrying his body.”

“Oh, Joseph,” Nani Humma moaned. “Will the suffering ever be over?”

“Before you tell the others, know this,” Joseph said. “Isaac always knew he would never reach our new home alive. He knew he would become a ghost. Now that it has happened, he is not afraid. His pain is over. He is with us now, and will stay with us till we rescue Naomi.”

“You are a brave young man,” Nani Humma said.

When we were alone again, Joseph lifted his palms, and asked, “Are you with me?”

“Yes,” I assured him, and floated into view.

“No reason to wait. Let’s go,” he said.

The river curved way from the road. We left the riverbank and entered a thicket of oak trees. Joseph crept quietly, till we saw the flickering light of the soldiers' campfire.

"She's in the middle wagon," Joseph said.

Easier to keep an eye on her there, I thought.

"Isaac," he said, "the soldiers would see me before I reached her wagon, or they'd catch me when she cried out. She doesn't know me."

"She doesn't know me either," I said. But I knew what he was thinking.

"No," Joseph said, "but you can climb into the wagon without being seen. And you can whisper so soft, she'll listen to you. No Choctaw would scream to drive a ghost away, you know that. This is a job for you."

I knew he was right. "*Hoke*," I said. "But stay close!"

"I'll be right here, but what are you worried about?"

He was right. *What did I have to worry about?* That's when I realized, for the first time, that the soldiers couldn't hurt me. I was already dead! Maybe being a ghost wasn't so bad after all.

With my newfound courage, I walked to the soldiers' campfire. I sat down next to the man who had passed out the smallpox blankets. He could not see me, of course.

A young man was scooping beef stew from a large kettle and filling their bowls. He was Luke's age, more or less, but his arms were long and thin. His black hair was cut short, and I could see he was Choctaw.

Where is Naomi? I asked myself. *I thought she was their helper.*

Dumb me! Of course, this was Naomi, dressed like a teenage boy, with short-cut hair. *I have to be smarter than this*, I told myself.

“Hey, don’t be so stingy,” shouted a skinny soldier with a long pointy nose. “Gimme more stew! And where’s the bread?”

Naomi took his bowl and refilled it. She hurried to the breadbasket and then handed over thick chunks of cornbread to every soldier.

“That’s better,” said Pointy Nose.

I waited and watched. The steam rose from the stewpot, but I couldn’t smell a thing. Once Naomi tripped and splashed stew on my face. I jumped, out of habit. But I didn’t feel anything, no blistery, burning skin.

When supper was over, the lead soldier stood up. He had curly black hair and a thick chest. I knew he would be a tough man to beat in a fight. He also had a serious look on his face.

“All right, we have another long day tomorrow,” he said. “Let’s get to bed.” The others finished off their remaining stew and unrolled their blankets. I saw that some slept in the wagons; others, on the ground by the fire.

Those must be the guards, I thought.

“Who’s got first watch?” Leader asked.

“Not me,” said Pointy Nose.

“I’ll take it,” said a short, round soldier.

The other guards took off their boots and slipped under their blankets. Roundman rolled a log by the fire and sat down. His shotgun lay across his lap.

Moving among the soldiers should be easy, I knew that. But I also knew I had to be careful. If I knocked anything over or made too much noise, they would look for somebody sneaking around their camp.

I knew these men wouldn't care if they shot the right man or not. The closest Choctaw to their camp might end up dead because of me. It might be Nani Humma, wandering by the river at night.

I couldn't live with myself if that happened.

Naomi gathered the dirty bowls and stood by the campfire. The logs burned low and embers sparkled in the dark night air. I heard frogs calling from the river. Pointy Nose brought her a bucket of water, and Naomi washed the bowls.

“Let’s go,” Leader said to Naomi. She followed him to the middle covered wagon, and they climbed aboard.

He’s tying her up with a rope, I thought.

I decided not to wait. When everyone was sleeping, any noise would alert the guards. Now was the time.

I tiptoed to the middle wagon. The wagon bed was high off the ground. Normally, I would have grabbed the rear board and swung my legs onto the wagon bed. But that would make too much noise.

I slid one arm over the rear board and scooted on my belly like a snake, trying to lift myself on the wagon. I fell through the wagon bed and hit the ground below!

I jumped to my feet and got ready to run.

Nobody moved. Nobody had heard me.

I tried to climb on the wagon again, but I kept falling to the ground.

“Isaac,” Mister Jonah said, and he was laughing. “You need to remember, you are a ghost. You can’t grab or move anything. You can’t knock anything over; don’t worry about that.”

“How can I get inside the wagon then?” I asked. *Being a ghost was not so easy after all.*

“It’s easier than you think,” he said. “Just imagine where you want to be, and you’re there.”

“Do I close my eyes, like before?”

“You can if you want to,” he said, still laughing, “but nobody else does.”

"Hoke," I said, "I am inside the wagon." And I was! Mister Jonah was gone, and I floated above Naomi.

She lay curled up in a corner; her feet and hands tied to a thick nail. The ropes that bound her were short, forcing her to lie in the same spot. If she grew sore, she couldn't roll over, like everybody else does when they sleep.

I hovered above her and watched for a long moment. Her face was buried in her hands and she was crying.

"Naomi," I finally whispered.

"What took you so long?" she said.



Chapter 20

Naomi the Strong

“WHAT TOOK ME so long!” I said, far too loud. I clamped my hands over my mouth and listened. Nobody had heard me. Nobody *could* hear me.

“*Hoke*,” I whispered. “What do you mean, ‘What took me so long?’ Do you know who I am?”

“No,” Naomi said. “I do not know who you are. But I have been dreaming about you for a week. Every night you climb into my wagon. You are here to help me escape. But I cannot go with you.”

I let her see me.

“Oooh,” she said. Her voice was filled with wonder. “You are a ghost. I didn’t know you would be a ghost.”

"I have only been a ghost since this evening," I told her. "A wolf killed me, but I'm *hoke* now. Don't worry about me. We need to get you home to your family. We've been planning your escape for several days."

"Is that why the Choctaw councilwomen come by?"

"Yes. You see everything, don't you?" I said.

"I have to be watchful to stay alive," Naomi said. "But you must understand. I can't leave or the soldiers will take my little sister."

"I know Nita," I said. "And I know your family. They walk with mine."

"How are they?" Naomi asked.

"They are sad, Naomi. Nita is gone. She died four days ago."

Naomi shook her head. "No," she said. Fat balls of tears rolled down her cheeks. "Not my little sister. How did she die?"

“She rolled out of her blanket and froze to death,” I said. “Nita is my little sister, too. She adopted me.”

Naomi shook with sadness, and I waited for her to finish crying. Grieving is hard. Lives are changed forever by grieving.

“The soldiers can’t hurt her anymore,” she sobbed. “They already killed her.” After a long time, she wiped the tears from her eyes and asked, “Can you talk to her?”

“Yes,” I said. “It was Nita’s idea that we bring you home. She said you would make your family happy again. That’s why I am here, Naomi.”

I should have known Nita would follow me. But I was as surprised as Naomi when I heard her voice.

“Naomi,” Nita giggled. “Give me a big hug.” Nita shone like a pale moon. I could see through her. But there she was, wrapping her ghost arms around her big sister, Naomi.

“Nita,” Naomi said. “I am so happy to see you!”

“See,” Nita said. “You can make Mommy and Daddy happy, too.”

I wanted to talk to Naomi about an escape plan. But that never happened, not on this night.

“Naomi!” A voice shouted from the rear of the wagon. Leader waved a bright lantern from one corner of the wagon to the other.

“Who’s in there with you? I heard voices.”

“No one,” Naomi said, trembling. “I was having a nightmare. I must have been talking in my sleep. I am sorry I woke you.”

Leader held the lantern close to the ground and circled the wagon.
He is looking for tracks, I thought. I hope ghosts don't leave footprints.

"Who were you talking to?" Leader hollered, louder than before.

"No one," Naomi said. "I was asleep."

He knew she was lying. He climbed into the wagon and untied her hands and feet. With one strong arm he lifted her and tossed her to the ground.

I jumped to her side and tried to drag her away. My hands passed through her. I could do nothing to help her.

This was all my fault.

I wanted to run to the river for Joseph, but I was afraid to leave Naomi. Leader was so mad. I feared he would hurt her.

“Don’t move!” Leader shouted. He took a rope from the wagon and tossed it over a strong tree limb. I froze at the horror of what I was watching.

No, please no. He is going to hang her! I thought.

Leader grabbed Naomi by the waist. The other soldiers stood watching. They knew better than to say a word, but I could tell what they were thinking. It was written on their faces: *When Leader is this mad, he’ll strike anyone or anything in his way.* They stared without moving as Leader dragged Naomi to the rope, dangling on the ground beneath the tree.

“Give me your hands!” he said.

Naomi lifted her hands, and he tied the rope tight around her wrists. “I need some help!” he yelled.

Roundman and Pointy Noise ran to his side.

“Take this rope and pull it till I say stop,” he ordered.

They tugged on the rope and Naomi rose to her feet, lifted by the rope tied to her wrists. She clenched her jaw tight shut. I saw by the wild look in her eyes that Naomi was afraid for her life.

They pulled on the rope till Naomi was standing, her arms high over her head.

“Keep pulling!” Leader shouted. “I didn’t say stop!”

Pointy Nose and Round man yanked hard on the rope.

“Ohhhh!” Naomi screamed. Leader slapped her hard across the face.

“You will never lie to me again,” he said. He moved his face so close to hers, I could not hear what he was saying. It must have been horrible. Naomi closed her eyes and shook her head back and forth.

When Naomi's feet were at his waist, Leader turned back to his helpers.

"Now, you can stop," he said. "Tie the rope to the tree trunk." Naomi swung slowly, twisting and swaying. Her face was etched in pain.

"Now," Leader said. "It's getting late. We have a long day tomorrow. Men, let's get some sleep."

As if she were a dog tied to a stake, they left her. They left my new friend Naomi hanging from a tree. I heard a soft cry and knew without looking who it was.

"We did this to her. Didn't we?" Nita said.

"Yes, Nita, I think we did," I said. There was no reason to lie. "But we will not leave her here."

We hurried to the river, where Joseph was waiting.

"Joseph," I said, "you have to see this." I led him to the soldiers' campsite. By the light of the dying fire, Naomi hung.

"We can't wait any longer," Joseph said. "Naomi comes with us tonight."